M7 — Hypergradients, diffusion samplers, a scaling law (N3, N8, O6)

jax-experiments writeup · M7

2026-10-19

Contents

N3 — Learning the learning rate: hypergradients through training **2**
- Question . . . 2
- The idea . . . 2
- The math . . . 3
- What we measure and why . . . 3
- What I built . . . 4
- Results . . . 4
- What surprised me . . . 7
- Open threads . . . 7

N8 — Diffusion samplers: DDIM, x0 and v, and the cosine schedule's first step **7**
- Question . . . 7
- The idea . . . 8
- The math . . . 8
- What we measure and why . . . 8
- What I built . . . 9
- Results . . . 9
- What surprised me . . . 11
- Open threads . . . 11

O6 — A scaling law on tokens **12**
- Question . . . 12
- The idea . . . 12
- The math . . . 12
- What we measure and why . . . 13
- What I built . . . 13
- Results . . . 13
- What surprised me . . . 15
- Open threads . . . 15

Status: N3, N8 and O6 done ·
Hardware: Kaggle T4 ×2 (one job per GPU), JAX 0.11.1; N3's constant-LR controls on a Colab T4 (same JAX, Flax and Optax versions); CPU (4 cores) for the tests, N8's seed-2 diagnosis and O6's token caches ·
Data: N3: `data/n3-summary.json` and `data/n3/` (one JSON and log per job; the first run, whose landscape batches were not yet keyed, in `data/n3/first-run/`); N8: `data/n8-summary.json` and `data/n8/` (one JSON and log per seed, sample grids as `.npy`, the CPU diagnosis of seed 2, and the first run, without the PyTorch control, in `data/n8/first-run/`); O6: `data/o6-summary.json` and `data/o6/` (the LR sweeps, the 18 IsoFLOP jobs, `lr-table.json`, and the kernels' logs) ·
Reproduce: N3: `uv run python tools/kaggle/push_r2.py <preset> --push` for `n3b`, `n3c` and `n3d`; the controls are `experiments/n3_hypergrad/run.py --studies reference --constant-lr <1e-3|2e-3> --seed <0|1|2>`; then `uv run python experiments/n3_hypergrad/analyze.py`. N8: preset `n8b` (its seed 0 lane failed on the MNIST race and was rerun as a lane of O6's `o6e`), then `uv run python experiments/n8_diffusion/analyze.py`; the seed-2 diagnosis is `PYTHONPATH=src python experiments/n8_diffusion/diag_seed2.py <out.json>` (CPU, ~1 h). O6: `run.py --studies tokenize` on CPU builds the token caches (uploaded as the private Kaggle dataset `jaxexp-bpe`); presets `o6a` and `o6e` (LR), `o6c` and `o6d` (IsoFLOP); then `uv run python experiments/o6_scaling/analyze.py` (~20 min, mostly the bootstrap). CPU tests: `uv run pytest tests/test_n3_hypergrad.py tests/test_n8_diffusion.py tests/test_o6_bpe.py`

N3 — Learning the learning rate: hypergradients through training

Question

N1 found the 4M transformer's best learning rate by search: 18 runs, one per (LR, seed). Training is a differentiable function of its learning rate, so `jax.grad` can, in principle, find that rate by gradient instead. Two questions:

- **Does the hypergradient point at the tuned LR?** Starting from a point in training and looking K steps ahead, which LR does the gradient prefer, and how does it compare with the LR the tuned schedule uses at that point?
- **Can it set the LR online?** Train 3,000 steps with the LR updated by its own hypergradient every K steps, and compare the final bits/byte with the tuned schedule.

The literature predicts a specific failure: **short-horizon bias**. Hypergradients over short horizons favour small, greedy learning rates, because a small step reduces the loss soonest even when a larger one would reach a lower loss later (Wu et al. 2018).

The idea

Training is a function, so it has a derivative. K steps of AdamW map $(\theta_0, \eta_1, \dots, \eta_K)$ to θ_K. The validation loss after them, $L_{\text{val}}(\theta_K)$, is a scalar function of the learning rates, and reverse mode differentiates it through every step: through the forward and backward passes of each step (a second derivative of the model), through Adam's moments and bias correction, through the clipping and the weight decay.

The meta-loss. Its gradient with respect to $\log \eta$ (log, so that a step changes the LR by a factor) is the hypergradient. Its zero crossing is the LR that minimises the loss K steps later: the *K-step-greedy* LR.

What it costs. Reverse mode through K steps stores what each step's backward pass needs. With `jax.checkpoint` around every step, it stores only the carry (θ, m, v: three copies of the parameters) per step and recomputes the rest, so memory grows with K times 50 MB for the 4M model rather than K times the activations.

The math

One AdamW step, as ml-ladder's protocol runs it (clipping at global norm 1, $\beta = (0.9, 0.95)$, $\epsilon = 10^{-8}$, decoupled weight decay $\lambda = 0.1$):

$$g \leftarrow g \min\!\left(1, \tfrac{1}{\|g\|}\right), \quad m \leftarrow \beta_1 m + (1-\beta_1) g, \quad v \leftarrow \beta_2 v + (1-\beta_2) g^2,$$

$$\theta \leftarrow \theta - \eta \left(\frac{m/(1-\beta_1^t)}{\sqrt{v/(1-\beta_2^t)} + \epsilon} + \lambda \theta \right).$$

The hypergradient for the segment's shared LR is

$$\frac{\partial L_{\text{val}}(\theta_K)}{\partial \log \eta} = \sum_{k=1}^{K} \eta_k \frac{\partial L_{\text{val}}(\theta_K)}{\partial \eta_k},$$

the sum of the per-step hypergradients; the code computes both. Each $\partial \theta_K / \partial \eta_k$ propagates through the later steps' Jacobians $\partial \theta_{j+1} / \partial \theta_j$, which contain the Hessian of the training loss. That is where the second derivative enters.

Why a short horizon prefers a small LR. On a quadratic valley with curvature h, gradient descent at rate η shrinks the error along it by $(1-\eta h)$ per step. Over a short horizon the loss is dominated by the highest-curvature directions, which a large η overshoots (or destabilises), while the low-curvature directions, where a large η pays, contribute only over many steps. The greedy optimum therefore sits below the long-run optimum, and the shorter the horizon, the further below.

What we measure and why

- **Equivalence (CPU).** The differentiable AdamW equals the training optimiser (`jaxexp.train.optimizer(`
step for step. The hypergradient equals a central finite difference (float64), and remat changes nothing.
- **The reference.** The tuned protocol in this setting: 3,000 steps of 64 × 256 bytes, peak 8e-3 (the best LR at T=256 in ml-ladder's `c-gpu-lr2-256.json` and in O3), 5% warmup, cosine to 10%, fp32. It saves checkpoints at steps 500 and 1,500.
- **The landscape.** From step 0 and the two checkpoints, for K = 10, 30 and 100: the meta-loss after K steps at nine constant LRs (2.5e-4 to 6.4e-2, factors of 2) and its hypergradient. The same K training batches and the same 64 held-out windows are used at every LR, so the curve is a deterministic function of the LR; they are keyed by (seed, start, K). The K-step-greedy LR is the hypergradient's zero crossing; it is compared with the schedule's mean LR over the same K steps.
- **Online.** 3,000 steps with no schedule. Every K = 30 steps, the hypergradient of the meta-loss after that segment (fresh held-out windows each time) updates $\log \eta$ by Adam (step 0.05). It starts from 1e-3 (too small), 8e-3 (the tuned peak) and 3.2e-2 (too large). A segment whose loss or hypergradient is not finite is undone and the LR halved. The runs from 1e-3 and 8e-3 are repeated with each hypergradient clipped to ± 1 before Adam sees it. Final bits/byte is on the same 262,144 validation bytes as every other run.
- **The control.** The same training stream at a constant 1e-3 and 2e-3, with no hypergradient: does the adaptation beat leaving the LR alone?

- **Held-out windows.** The meta-objective's windows come from the validation split after its first 1,000,000 bytes, so they never overlap the bytes on which bits/byte is reported.

What I built

- **`jaxexp.hypergrad`:**
  - `adamw_init` and `adamw_step`: ml-ladder's AdamW written out so the LR is a traced input. Its square root has a zero derivative at 0 (see below).
  - `make_unroll`: K steps in `lax.scan`, with `jax.checkpoint` on each step.
  - `make_meta_loss`: the validation loss after K steps, as a function of $\log \eta$ (one value, or one per step).
- **`experiments/n3_hypergrad/run.py`** (studies `reference`, `landscape`, `online`; `--clip-hypergrad` for the online runs, `--constant-lr` for the control), `analyze.py`, and the Kaggle presets `n3b`, `n3c` and `n3d`.
- **Tests:** `tests/test_n3_hypergrad.py`, 4 tests.
  - **A NaN the tests found.** The attention key bias has a gradient of exactly zero, because softmax ignores a shift shared by all keys. Its Adam second moment is then exactly 0, the derivative of $\sqrt{v}$ there is infinite, and reverse mode multiplies it by zero: NaN in every hypergradient. The fix is a square root whose derivative at 0 is 0; the forward value is unchanged.
  - **Finite differences on the transformer agree only to 0.13%.** Even in float64, the transformer's meta-loss is not smooth below about 10^{-9}, so the exact check uses a small attention-free model (agreement 3.5×10^{-9}). On the transformer, the test checks that reverse and forward mode agree.

Results

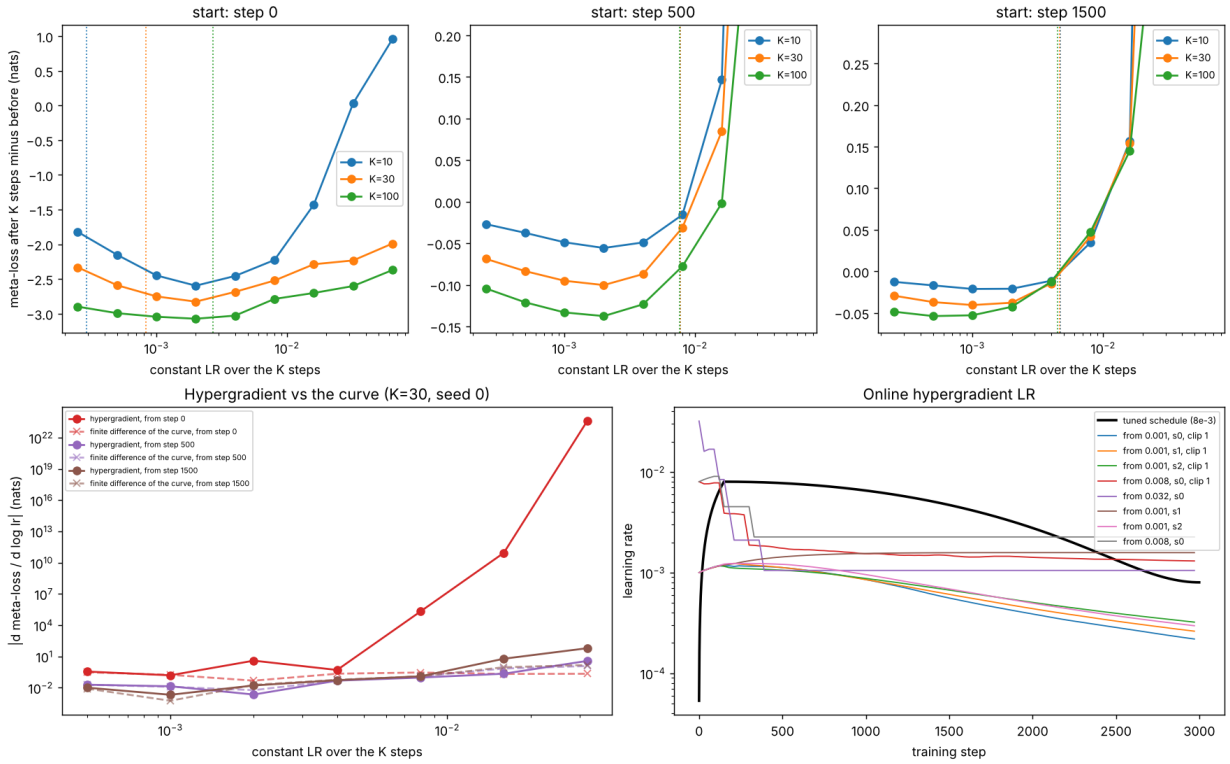


Figure 1: N3: the meta-loss after K steps at constant LRs from three points of the tuned run (seed 0; dotted: the schedule's mean LR over those steps); the hypergradient against the curve's finite differences; and the online LR trajectories.

The reference reproduces ml-ladder. The tuned schedule (peak 8e-3) reaches 1.6338 bits/byte (1.6303–1.6358) in fp32, against ml-ladder's 1.6308 (1.6239–1.6339) in fp16 PyTorch at the same LR. It trains at 4.8–5.5 steps/s.

The K-step-greedy LR (the meta-loss curve's minimum). Medians over seeds 0–2, with min–max. The greedy LR is the vertex of a parabola in $\log \eta$ through the grid minimum and its neighbours; no minimum lies at the grid's edge.

start	K	greedy LR	schedule's mean LR	greedy / schedule	hypergradient matches the curve up to	explodes from
0	10	1.7e-3 (1.6–2.0e-3)	2.9e-4	5.97 (5.61–6.88)	1e-3	1.6e-2 – 6.4e-2
0	30	1.8e-3 (1.8–1.8e-3)	8.3e-4	2.18 (2.15–2.18)	5e-4 – 1e-3	8e-3
0	100	1.8e-3 (1.7–1.9e-3)	2.7e-3	0.66 (0.65–0.69)	5e-4 – 1e-3	2e-3 – 4e-3
500	10	1.9e-3 (1.7–2.0e-3)	7.7e-3	0.25 (0.22–0.26)	4e-3 – 8e-3	3.2e-2 – none
500	30	1.5e-3 (1.3–1.7e-3)	7.7e-3	0.20 (0.17–0.22)	4e-3 – 8e-3	1.6e-2 – 6.4e-2
500	100	1.7e-3 (1.6–1.8e-3)	7.7e-3	0.22 (0.21–0.23)	2e-3	8e-3 – 1.6e-2
1500	10	1.2e-3 (1.1–1.4e-3)	4.7e-3	0.26 (0.24–0.29)	8e-3	3.2e-2 – none
1500	30	1.0e-3 (0.91–1.0e-3)	4.6e-3	0.22 (0.20–0.22)	8e-3	3.2e-2 – 6.4e-2
1500	100	7.2e-4 (6.4–9.3e-4)	4.5e-3	0.16 (0.14–0.21)	2e-3 – 8e-3	1.6e-2 – 3.2e-2

"Matches" means within half the curve's central difference (or 0.02 nats near zero), at every grid LR up to that one. "Explodes" means the hypergradient is not finite or exceeds 10 in magnitude, where the curve's own slope is below 1. "None" means it never exploded on the grid.

- **Short-horizon bias, as predicted.** Once warmup is over, the greedy LR is a fifth to a quarter of what the tuned schedule uses at that point (0.16–0.26 by median). The greedy choice is not wrong over its own horizon: over the K steps, it lowers the held-out loss by 0.02 to 0.07 nats more than the schedule's LR does. The schedule's large LR pays only over the whole run.
- **A longer horizon does not close the gap.** From step 1500 the ratio falls from 0.26 at K = 10 to 0.16 at K = 100. Holding a constant LR for longer favours a smaller one (it lowers the noise floor). Horizons of 10–100 steps never reach the regime where a large LR wins.
- **At initialisation it is the other way round.** Over the first 10 steps the greedy LR is 6× the warmup's: warmup is cautious, not greedy. By K = 100 the ratio is 0.66.
- **The hypergradient has a trust region.** From steps 500 and 1500 it matches the curve up to 4e-3–8e-3 for K ≤ 30, and up to 2e-3–8e-3 at K = 100. From step 0 it matches only up to 5e-4–1e-3, below the greedy LR itself. Above that it disagrees, even in sign (seed 1, step 0, K = 10, at 2e-3: −0.69 against the curve's +0.12), and then it explodes: from 2e-3 at K =

100 from step 0, and from 8e-3 or more after warmup. The meta-loss itself stays smooth throughout. Its zero crossing would have put the greedy LR at 3.9e-3 for that seed, against the curve's 1.7e-3.

Online. Every 30 steps, Adam (step 0.05) updates $\log \eta$ with the segment's hypergradient. 3,000 steps; bits/byte on the same 262,144 validation bytes.

start LR	hypergradient	seeds	bits/byte	LR at steps 150 / 1,500 / 2,970
1e-3	clipped to ± 1	0, 1, 2	1.8043 (1.8031–1.8210)	1.2e-3 / 5.6–6.7e-4 / 2.2–3.2e-4
1e-3	raw	0, 1, 2	1.7880 (1.7746–1.8388)	see below
8e-3	clipped to ± 1	0	2.3581	3.9e-3 / 1.5e-3 / 1.3e-3
8e-3	raw	0	2.2609	4.5e-3 / 2.3e-3 / 2.3e-3
3.2e-2	raw	0	3.0003	8.4e-3 / 1.1e-3 / 1.1e-3
constant 1e-3 (no hypergradient)	—	0, 1, 2	1.8145 (1.8042–1.8229)	—
constant 2e-3 (no hypergradient)	—	0, 1, 2	1.7604 (1.7461–1.7773)	—
tuned schedule (peak 8e-3)	—	0, 1, 2	1.6338 (1.6303–1.6358)	8.0e-3 / 4.7e-3 / 8.0e-4

- **Hypergradient descent learns to anneal, greedily.** With clipping, the LR rises from 1e-3 to about 1.2e-3 in the first 150 steps. It then falls steadily, to 5.6–6.7e-4 at step 1,500 and 2.2–3.2e-4 at the end: a decay schedule, discovered online. It ends 0.17 bits/byte behind the tuned schedule, whose LR is 3–8× higher throughout.
- **And it gains nothing over leaving the LR alone.** Seed by seed, the clipped online run from 1e-3 minus a constant 1e-3 on the same training stream is -0.002, -0.011 and $+0.000$ bits/byte. A constant 2e-3 beats every online run (1.7461–1.7773). Rising a little and then annealing, it ends where it would have ended had it never moved.
- **Raw hypergradients break the meta-optimiser rather than the model.** One exploding value (10^{13} to 10^{27}) fills Adam's second moment, and every later update of $\log \eta$ is then about zero: the LR freezes. Seed 1 (raw, from 1e-3) met one value of -539 at step 210; its LR then crept up to 1.6e-3 and stayed there, and it finished at 1.7746, *better* than any clipped run, and level with a constant 2e-3 on that seed (1.7773). Seed 2 never exploded and annealed like the clipped runs (1.7880). Seed 0 is the first run's: it never exploded, annealed to 1.8e-4 and finished at 1.8388 (`data/n3/first-run/`).
- **Starting at the tuned peak, without warmup, is worse than starting low.** From 8e-3 the hypergradients explode at once (47 of 100 segments raw, 53 clipped). The guard halves the LR twice in the first 300 steps (two segments undone), and the run never recovers: 2.26–2.36 bits/byte, worse than any run from 1e-3. From 3.2e-2: 3.00.
- **Cost.** An online run took 3.9× the reference's wall time (2,175–2,318 s against 544–624 s): each segment differentiates through 30 remat'd steps, then evaluates 64 held-out windows.

What surprised me

- **The hypergradient goes wrong before it blows up.** I expected it either to work or to overflow. Instead, from step 0 it has the wrong size, and sometimes the wrong sign, at LRs where the meta-loss curve is perfectly smooth. Its trust region there lies *below* the greedy LR. Reverse mode multiplies 10–100 Jacobians of the training map. Once their product grows, the derivative stops describing the function, long before it overflows.
- **Longer horizons made the greedy LR smaller, not larger.** The textbook story says short horizons favour small LRs and longer ones relax towards the tuned value. Here, for a constant LR held over the horizon, the optimum fell from 1.2e-3 to 7.2e-4 between K = 10 and K = 100 (from step 1500).
- **The damage was done to the meta-optimiser, not the model.** One hypergradient of 10^{27} is harmless to the weights (the LR step is bounded), but it fills Adam's second moment for the rest of the run (it decays by 0.999 per update; the run has 100 updates). The run that froze by accident at 1.6e-3 beat every run whose LR kept adapting.
- **The first 10 steps want 6× the warmup's LR.** Measured greedily, warmup looks too timid. But the run that started at the tuned peak with no warmup never recovered (2.26 bits/byte), so a greedy 10-step view of warmup misses what it protects against.

Open threads

- **Forward mode over the whole run.** With one or two hyperparameters (peak LR, warmup length), a JVP through all 3,000 steps costs a few training runs and no extra memory. It has no horizon bias at all, but the same Jacobian product grows inside it: would it explode the same way?
- **Unbiased estimators for long horizons.** Persistent evolution strategies (Vicol et al. 2021) smooth the meta-loss instead of differentiating it, and avoid the exploding product. The landscape here, with its known greedy optima, is a ready-made test bed.
- **The per-step hypergradient** along the tuned schedule was recorded at every start (`schedule_hypergrad_per_step`) and is not analysed here. It says which steps of the schedule want more or less LR.
- **The clipping threshold** (± 1) was not tuned, and nor was the meta step (0.05). The greedy annealing, though, looks like a property of the objective rather than of the optimiser: the landscape's greedy LR falls along the run too (K = 30: 1.5e-3 from step 500, 1.0e-3 from step 1500).

N8 — Diffusion samplers: DDIM, x0 and v, and the cosine schedule's first step

Question

E3 trained a 245k-parameter DDPM on MNIST at T = 400 and sampled it with DDPM's ancestral sampler. Its open threads were DDIM's deterministic sampler, T = 1000 and v-prediction. Three questions:

- **Does the JAX port reproduce E3?** Same U-Net, data subset, optimiser, schedules and sampler; scored by E3's own Fréchet distance.
- **How few steps can each sampler take?** DDPM against DDIM at 10 to 1,000 steps, for ε-, x_0- and v-prediction, linear and cosine schedules, T = 1000.
- **What does a sampler cost when the whole loop is one compiled program?**

The idea

One network, three targets. The forward process is $x_t = \sqrt{\bar{\alpha}_t}\, x_0 + \sqrt{1-\bar{\alpha}_t}\, \epsilon$. The network can be trained to output ε (DDPM), x_0, or $v = \sqrt{\bar{\alpha}_t}\, \epsilon - \sqrt{1-\bar{\alpha}_t}\, x_0$ (Salimans and Ho 2022). Any one of them, with x_t, determines the other two, so every sampler runs on every parameterisation.

Two samplers on the same network. DDPM's ancestral step adds fresh noise at every step. DDIM with $\eta = 0$ is deterministic: it predicts x_0 and re-noises it to the next retained timestep along the predicted ε. Both can skip timesteps; E3 strides DDPM by recomputing the effective α between retained steps.

The math

From an ε-prediction, the clean image is

$$\hat{x}_0 = \frac{x_t - \sqrt{1-\bar{\alpha}_t}\, \hat{\epsilon}}{\sqrt{\bar{\alpha}_t}},$$

and DDIM's update to the previous retained timestep $s < t$ is

$$x_s = \sqrt{\bar{\alpha}_s}\, \hat{x}_0 + \sqrt{1-\bar{\alpha}_s}\, \hat{\epsilon}.$$

An error δ in $\hat{\epsilon}$ moves x_s by

$$\left(\sqrt{\bar{\alpha}_s} \sqrt{\frac{1-\bar{\alpha}_t}{\bar{\alpha}_t}} - \sqrt{1-\bar{\alpha}_s} \right) \delta.$$

At the first step, $t = T - 1$. **The cosine schedule ends at** $\bar{\alpha}_T = 2.4 \times 10^{-9}$ (T = 1000; linear: 4.0×10^{-5}). With 10 steps, the first jump goes to $s = 888$, where $\bar{\alpha}_s = 0.030$. That multiplies δ by about 3,500 under the cosine schedule and by 1.9 under the linear one. At 1,000 steps the factor is 31 (cosine) against 0.01 (linear). ε-prediction is therefore fragile exactly where few-step sampling needs it. x_0- and v-prediction never divide by $\sqrt{\bar{\alpha}_t}$. Clipping $\hat{x}_0$ to the data range $[-1, 1]$, then recomputing $\hat{\epsilon}$ from it, bounds the damage.

What we measure and why

- **E3's arm** (T = 400, ε, linear and cosine; DDPM at 10, 25, 50, 100 and 400 steps), seeds 0–2. E3's protocol throughout:
  - the same 12,000 training and 2,000 test images per seed (`rng.choice` with `default_rng(seed)`);
  - AdamW at 2e-3, weight decay 10^{-5}, batch 128, 16 epochs;
  - 500 samples per score.
- **An in-job PyTorch control.** E3's own `UNet`, schedules, training loop and sampler, run in the same job on the same GPU and scored by the same scorer. ml-ladder's E3 numbers were recorded on a CPU, so this control separates "JAX differs" from "the hardware differs".
- **T = 1000.** Every combination of {ε, x_0, v} × {linear, cosine} is trained under E3's protocol. Each is sampled by DDPM and DDIM, each with and without x_0 clipping, at 10, 20, 50, 100 and 1,000 steps. The LR is E3's for every arm; it was not re-tuned per parameterisation.

- **The score.** ml-ladder's `generative` fd: a Fréchet distance in the feature space of a small classifier, trained per seed on that seed's training images (CPU, 2 epochs), between 500 samples and 500 test images. The floor is fd between two disjoint sets of 500 test images.
- **Cost.** Wall time of one compiled sampling run of 500 images, after a warm-up call.

What I built

- **`jaxexp.diffusion`:**
  - E3's schedules (verbatim) and its U-Net, written as pure functions with PyTorch's layer semantics and initialisation;
  - `from_torch`, which loads E3's weights;
  - the loss for each parameterisation;
  - `sample`, which runs DDPM or DDIM (optionally clipped) as one `lax.scan` over E3's timestep subsequence.
- **`experiments/n8_diffusion/run.py`:**
  - arms `e3`, `e3torch` and `t1000`, scored by ml-ladder's scorer;
  - `analyze.py`;
  - `diag_seed2.py`, a CPU diagnosis of one outlying seed.
- **Tests:** `tests/test_n8_diffusion.py`, 46 tests.
  - The JAX U-Net matches E3's PyTorch U-Net on loaded weights.
  - Each parameterisation's output converts back to (ε, x_0).
  - If the data is a single image, the exact denoiser is known in closed form. With it, every sampler, parameterisation and step count (10, 50, 1,000) ends at that image, to 10^{-4}.
- **A race fixed on the way.** n8b's two GPU lanes downloaded MNIST into the same directory at once, and one read the other's partial file (SHA mismatch). `jaxexp.data` now downloads to a per-process temporary file and renames it into place.

Results

fd is a median over seeds 0–2 with min–max; lower is better. Two disjoint sets of 500 test images score 0.17 (0.10–0.28), the floor. Seed noise is large: the same configuration often spans a factor of 2–5 across seeds. So comparisons between *separately trained models* (parameterisation, schedule, framework) need a pattern that holds seed by seed. Comparisons *within one model* (sampler, clipping, step count) are paired and much cleaner.

E3 reproduces, within seed noise. E3's arm at 400 DDPM steps:

	linear	cosine
JAX (this port)	2.22 (1.78–6.94)	2.65 (0.87–20.04)
E3's PyTorch, same job, same scorer	2.43 (1.57–2.76)	2.03 (1.24–2.41)
E3 as recorded (ml-ladder, CPU)	1.56 (1.42–2.23)	2.27 (1.25–2.50)

The final training MSE matches E3's (seed 0: 0.0284 linear in both JAX and PyTorch; cosine 0.0471 against 0.0465). The JAX medians lie inside PyTorch's range. **Seed 2's JAX models are the outliers (6.94 and 20.04), and the diagnosis shows the cause is the seed, not JAX.** Retrained on CPU, seed 2's linear model again samples thin, faint digits (fd 4.05; mean pixel 0.080 against MNIST's 0.131). Changing only the training key gives 2.40; changing only the data order gives

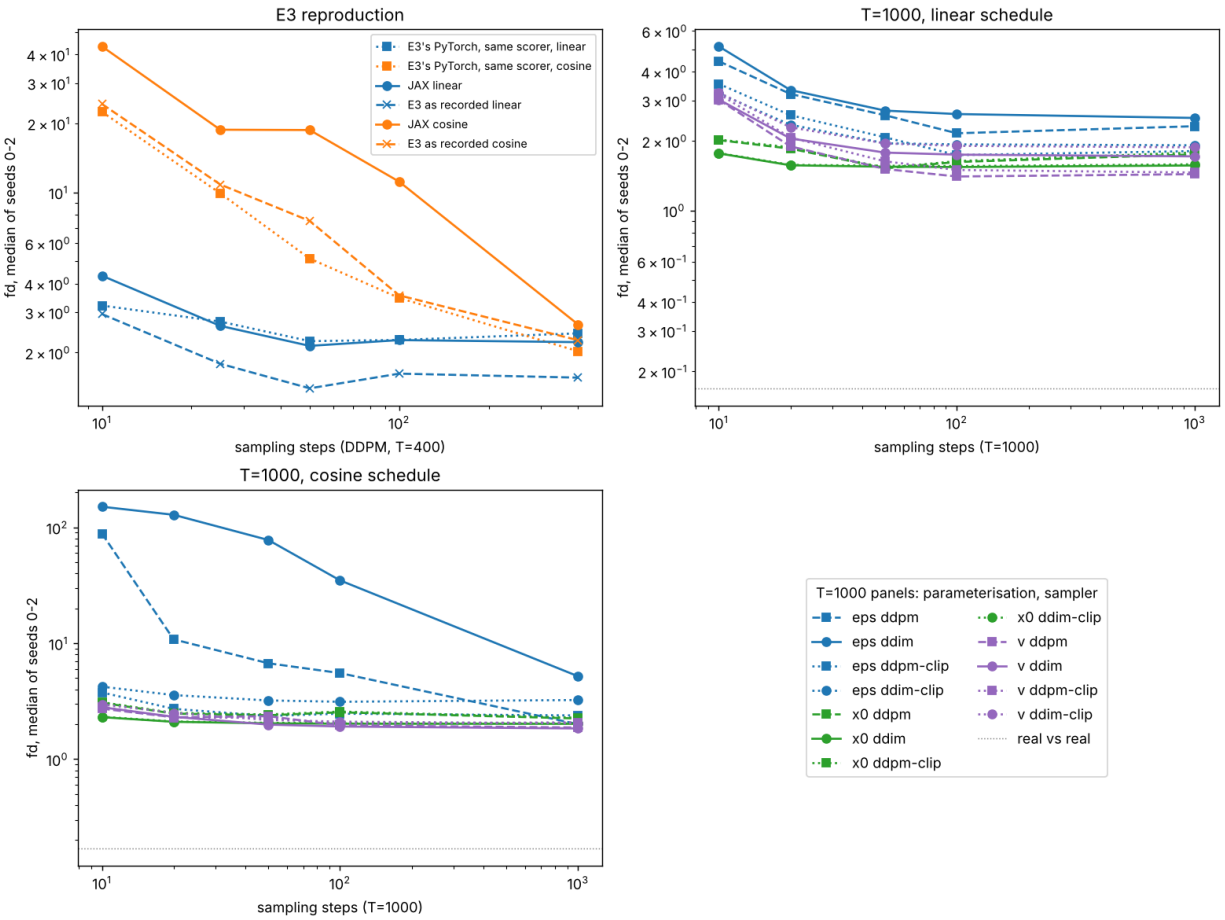


Figure 2: N8: fd (median of seeds 0–2) against sampling steps. Top left: E3's arm in JAX, E3's PyTorch model trained in the same job, and E3 as recorded. Top right and bottom left: T = 1000, every parameterisation and sampler (dotted grey: two sets of real test images).

1.64; another sampling key changes nothing (4.04). E3 trains at a constant LR with no weight averaging, so the final weights are a draw from the end of a noisy trajectory, and seed 2's draw is a bad one. The first run of this study (`data/n8/first-run/`) drew the same outlier (4.93 and 17.22).

Cosine ε collapses at few steps; clipping $\hat{x}_0$ fixes it. T = 1000, cosine, ε-prediction:

steps	DDPM	DDIM	DDPM, x_0 clipped	DDIM, x_0 clipped
10	88.5 (32.4–113.0)	150.9 (79.0–193.1)	3.77 (2.45–5.59)	4.22 (2.67–7.82)
20	10.8 (8.6–14.6)	128.6 (63.1–167.5)	2.72 (1.89–3.25)	3.57 (2.07–5.52)
100	5.54 (2.76–10.70)	34.9 (14.0–48.1)	2.47 (1.63–2.87)	3.13 (1.97–4.52)
1000	2.00 (1.84–3.16)	5.19 (3.54–17.78)	2.38 (1.75–3.19)	3.24 (1.91–4.47)

Model by model, clipping divides the 10-step DDPM fd by 12 to 33. This is the amplification of the first step in action: a gain of about 3,500 at 10 steps (see The math). E3's sampler does not clip, and E3's own cosine fd at 10 steps ranged from 9.0 to 153 across its seeds.

x_0-prediction is the few-step choice; v is the best at full length. T = 1000:

	10 steps	20 steps	100 steps	1,000 steps
ε, linear, DDPM	4.44 (3.31–5.36)	3.20 (2.41–3.73)	2.16 (1.74–3.03)	2.32 (1.73–3.34)
x_0, linear, DDIM	1.77 (1.61–3.54)	1.57 (1.38–3.38)	1.54 (1.35–3.28)	1.57 (1.32–3.41)
x_0, cosine, DDIM	2.30 (2.26–2.81)	2.10 (2.05–2.66)	2.03 (1.98–2.61)	2.02 (2.00–2.65)
v, linear, DDPM	3.02 (2.61–4.96)	1.90 (1.71–3.57)	1.40 (1.19–3.29)	1.44 (1.17–3.35)
v, cosine, DDIM	2.81 (2.00–3.11)	2.32 (1.69–2.61)	1.92 (1.57–2.46)	1.84 (1.55–2.44)

- **Steps to converge.** With DDIM, x_0-prediction reaches within 10% of its own 1,000-step fd by 10–20 steps on every seed and both schedules. Under the linear schedule ε-prediction needs 50 steps with DDIM and 50–100 with DDPM. Under the cosine schedule it needs 100–1,000 (DDIM) or the full 1,000 (DDPM).
- **On every seed the best sampler at 20 steps or fewer predicts x_0 or v, never ε.** Overall bests: linear v-DDPM, 1.40 at 100 steps; linear x_0-DDPM, 1.52 at 50.
- **Clipping is a fix for ε, not a free improvement.** Within each model, clipping changes x_0-prediction's fd by at most 5% (its estimate rarely leaves $[-1, 1]$). It never helps v-prediction at 20 steps or more: 0–16% *worse*, on every seed.
- **DDIM against DDPM depends on the model.** For x_0 under the cosine schedule DDIM is better on every seed at 10–20 steps (0.54–0.92× DDPM's fd), but not at 100 or more (seed 1: 1.11–1.13×). For linear ε, linear x_0 and v it is better on some seeds and worse on others; for unclipped cosine ε it is far worse.
- **T = 1000 does not beat T = 400 for E3's own model.** Linear ε-DDPM at full length: 2.32 (1.73–3.34) at T = 1000, against 2.22 (1.78–6.94) at T = 400.

Cost. One sampling run of 500 images costs 28 ms per step in JAX (27–29 across samplers and step counts), against 40–41 ms for E3's PyTorch loop on the same T4: 1.4× faster. Clipping and DDIM are free. Because the loop is one `lax.scan`, compiling takes 1.4–3.6 s whatever the step count. Training takes about the same in both (16 epochs: 47–55 s in JAX, 45 s in PyTorch).

What surprised me

- **A bad seed that reproduces.** XLA on a GPU is not deterministic, yet seed 2's E3 models were bad in both GPU runs and again on a CPU. Its training loss was normal (0.0282 against 0.0275–0.0284), so nothing in training flagged it. What stays fixed under all that run-to-run noise is the trajectory's seed, and the final weights of constant-LR training without averaging are a lottery ticket that the seed draws.
- **The cosine schedule is the fragile one.** It is usually introduced as the better schedule. With ε-prediction and few steps it is the worst configuration here by an order of magnitude, because it drives $\bar{\alpha}_T$ to 2.4×10^{-9}, and the first step divides by its square root.
- **Clipping $\hat{x}_0$ is not a free improvement.** It rescues cosine ε and never helps v at 20 steps or more.
- **More diffusion steps did not help E3's model.** T = 1000 matched T = 400 at full length, and the gains of this study came from the parameterisation and the sampler, not from T.

Open threads

- **Weight averaging.** An EMA of the weights is standard practice and should remove the final-iterate lottery. The one tried here (decay 0.999 over only 1,500 steps, no bias correction) still carried 22% of the initial weights and was worse (`data/n8/seed2-diagnosis.json`). A shorter decay or a bias-corrected average is the next thing to try.

- **Tune each parameterisation.** All arms used E3's LR. The three losses differ in scale (final MSE, linear schedule: ε 0.029, x_0 0.154, v 0.183), so one LR need not suit all three. "Tune every arm" was not followed here.
- **More seeds or more samples.** Differences under about 1 fd between separately trained models are inside the seed noise of three seeds and 500 samples.
- **Higher-order samplers** (DPM-Solver, Heun) are the obvious next arm for the few-step regime.

O6 — A scaling law on tokens

Question

G1 tried to measure the Chinchilla exponent on enwik8's characters and could not. Its compute-optimal N^* grew as $C^{1.24}$, because the corpus ran out: the largest IsoFLOP point repeated the training split 39.7 times. With ml-ladder's byte-exact BPE tokenizer and a corpus 11× larger, does the optimum become free to move? Does its exponent come with a range narrow enough to mean something?

The idea

Chinchilla's two approaches. At a fixed compute budget $C \approx 6ND$, train models of several sizes N, each on $D = C/(6N)$ tokens. The loss against $\log N$ is a valley (an IsoFLOP curve), and its bottom is the compute-optimal size $N^*(C)$. Repeating this at several budgets gives $N^* \propto C^a$ (approach 2). Alternatively, fit one surface $L(N, D) = E + A/N^\alpha + B/D^\beta$ through every run; it implies $a = \beta/(\alpha + \beta)$ (approach 3).

A corpus that does not run out. enwik8 is the first 10^8 bytes of enwik9. Training on enwik9 minus the bytes enwik8 holds out (90M–100M) gives about 990M bytes, which is 353M BPE tokens. Validation is ml-ladder's own held-out text, scored in bits per byte.

The math

Approach 2. Per budget, fit $L = c_0 + c_1 \log N + c_2 (\log N)^2$ through all runs; the vertex $\log N^* = -c_1/2c_2$ counts only if it lies strictly inside the sizes sampled. Then $\log N^* = a \log C + k$ over the interior contours, and $D^* = C/6N^*$ gives $b = 1 - a$.

Approach 3. Hoffmann et al.'s fit: minimise the Huber loss ($\delta = 10^{-3}$) of $\log L$ against $\mathrm{LSE}(a - \alpha \log N,\ b - \beta \log D,\ e)$ from a grid of 243 starting points, by L-BFGS-B.

What C counts. $6ND$ with non-embedding N is Kaplan's convention, and the budgets here are defined by it. A training token really costs

$$6\,(N + N_{\text{head}}) + 12\,n_{\text{layer}}\,T\,d$$

FLOPs: the 4096-way output layer ($N_{\text{head}} = 4096\,d$, 0.4M to 2.1M here) and causal attention (XLA computes all $T \times T$ scores). That is 3.2× the nominal cost for the smallest model and 1.17× for the largest. The parametric law $L(N, D)$ does not depend on how compute is counted, so the compute-optimal N under the true cost comes from minimising $L(N, C/\mathrm{cost}(N))$ over N.

What we measure and why

- **The tokenizer is ml-ladder's.** It must give 31,095,000 tokens on enwik8's training split and 2.8865 bytes per validation token.
- **LR per size.** Peak LR on a factor-2 grid at 2×10^7 tokens, seed 0, extended until every optimum is interior. G1 found per-size tuning essential.
- **IsoFLOP contours** at $C = 3 \times 10^{13}$, 10^{14}, 3×10^{14}, 10^{15}, 3×10^{15} and 10^{16} (nominal 6ND), seeds 0–2. Each of nine sizes runs where $2 \times 10^6 \leq D \leq$ the corpus.
- **Fixed for every run:** T = 256, 64 sequences per step, AdamW (0.9, 0.95), weight decay 0.1, clipping at 1, 5% warmup then cosine to 10% over each run's own length, fp16 matmuls with loss scaling, fused attention.
- **Uncertainty:** 5th–95th percentiles over 400 bootstrap resamples of the runs, for both approaches.
- **The parameter count:** approach 3 is repeated with the output layer counted in N, because that choice has been shown to move the exponent at small scale (Pearce and Song 2024).

What I built

- **`jaxexp.bpe`:**
  - ml-ladder's `train_bpe` and `bpe_encode`;
  - `enwik9`, checked against enwik8 by SHA (enwik8 must be its first 10^8 bytes);
  - `corpus`, which encodes in 100 MB chunks, checks that the tokens spell every byte exactly once, and caches the result as uint16 under one file lock.
- **`experiments/o6_scaling/run.py`:**
  - nine RoPE transformers, s0–s8: widths 96–512, 2–8 layers, 0.22M–25.2M non-embedding parameters;
  - the studies `tokenize`, `lr` and `isoflop`.
- **`analyze.py`:** both approaches, both parameter counts, the true-cost optimum and the bootstrap. `synthetic_check.py` runs it on data drawn from a known law at this design. It recovers $a = 0.483$ as 0.468 (IsoFLOP) and 0.460 (parametric, bootstrap 0.43–0.51).
- **`tests/test_o6_bpe.py`:** the tokens spell every byte once, and the vocabulary and encoding equal ml-ladder's.
- **The token caches** are built once on CPU and shipped as a private Kaggle dataset. One kernel that downloaded and tokenized enwik9 itself ran 3 h against 45 min expected, with no output, and was deleted. The runner now bounds every job's wall time.

Results

The tokenizer is ml-ladder's: 31,095,000 tokens on enwik8's training split and 2.8865 bytes per validation token, as recorded. The enwik9 training stream is 353,060,729 tokens.

LR per size (peak, 2×10^7 tokens, seed 0; every optimum is interior after the grid's extension): 1.6e-2 for s0–s2, 8e-3 for s3–s4 (s4: 1.5565 at 8e-3, 1.5578 at 4e-3), 4e-3 for s5–s6 and 2e-3 for s7–s8. The best LR halves for every 3–5× in parameters.

The IsoFLOP contours. 105 runs, 11.0 GPU-hours on T4s. At each contour's best size the three seeds span at most 0.017 bits/byte (0.001–0.005 above 3×10^{14}); far from the optimum, up to 0.047. Medians of seeds 0–2:

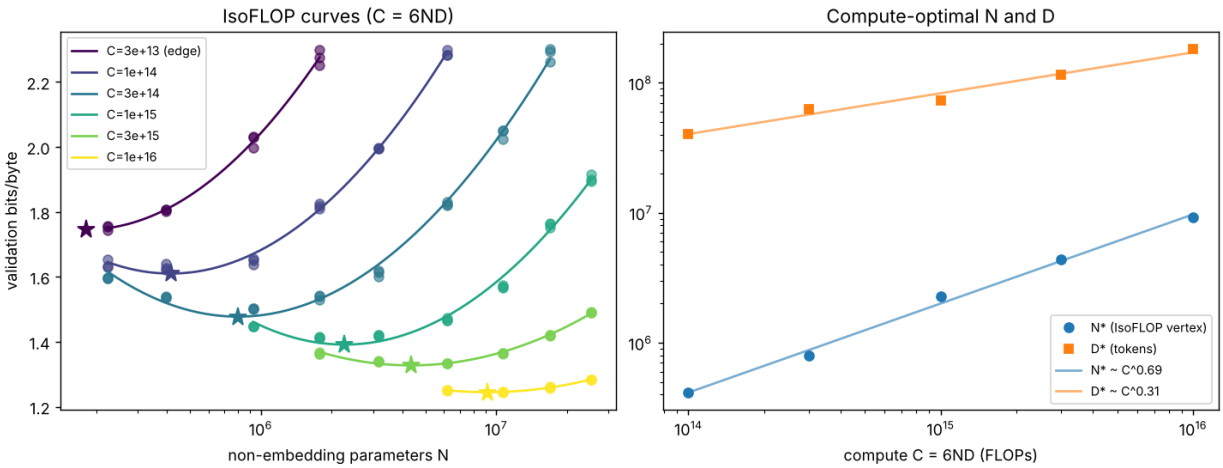


Figure 3: O6: IsoFLOP curves (all three seeds; stars mark each parabola's vertex) and the compute-optimal N and D over the interior contours.

C (6ND)	best size	its bits/byte	vertex N^*	D^*	tokens / parameter
3×10^{13}	s0 (0.22M, the smallest)	1.7531	0.18M — not interior		
10^{14}	s1 (0.40M)	1.6277	0.41M	40M	97
3×10^{14}	s2 (0.93M)	1.5019	0.80M	62M	78
10^{15}	s3 (1.78M)	1.4137	2.27M	73M	32
3×10^{15}	s5 (6.16M)	1.3336	4.35M	115M	26
10^{16}	s6 (10.6M)	1.2454	9.18M	181M	20

The exponent depends on what N counts.

method	a in $N^* \propto C^a$	5–95% (400 resamples)
IsoFLOP vertices (approach 2), non-embedding N	0.686	0.667–0.711
parametric (approach 3), non-embedding N	0.628	0.586–0.710
the same law, optimum under the true FLOP count	0.653	0.606–0.747
parametric, output layer counted in N	0.506	0.475–0.569

- **Five of six contours are interior**, over two decades of compute (10^{14}–10^{16}). The optimum is free to move, which G1's corpus never allowed. The approach-2 exponent does not depend on which sizes enter each parabola: the nearest 3, 4 or 5 sizes give 0.701, 0.681 and 0.683. Dropping 10^{16} gives 0.711; keeping only $C \geq 3 \times 10^{14}$ gives 0.686.
- **In Kaplan's convention the exponent is Kaplan-like.** With N counting only the blocks, $a = 0.63$–0.69 by either approach: models should grow much faster than data. Chinchilla's 0.5 is outside every bootstrap range. Tokens per parameter fall from 97 to 20 across the range.
- **Counting the output layer gives Chinchilla's exponent.** The same 105 runs, fit with the 4096-way output layer counted in N, give $a = 0.506$ (0.475–0.569). That layer is 0.4M–2.1M

parameters here: more than the blocks for s0–s1, and 8% of N plus the output layer at s8. Both fits describe the data equally well (2.2% RMS relative residual each). This is Pearce and Song's (2024) reconciliation of Kaplan and Chinchilla, reproduced at small scale: at small N, the exponent is partly a statement about what you count.

- **Counting compute properly matters less.** The true FLOPs are 3.2× the nominal 6ND for s0 and 1.17× for s8. Re-deriving the optimum under the true cost moves a from 0.628 to 0.653, inside the ranges.
- **The parametric law:** $\alpha = 0.36$ (0.25–0.43), $\beta = 0.61$ (0.55–0.69), and $E = 1.06$ (0.97–1.12) bits/byte with non-embedding N. Counting the output layer, $\alpha = 0.61$ (0.49–0.67), $\beta = 0.62$ (0.56–0.69), and $E = 1.11$ (1.06–1.16). β is twice Chinchilla's 0.28. The 2.2% residual is several times the seed spread near the optima, so the four-term law is only an approximation here. E is not an entropy estimate: it extrapolates beyond two decades of both N and D.

What surprised me

- **One dataset, two famous exponents.** I expected the true-FLOP correction (up to 3.2×) to be the convention that mattered. It moved the exponent by 0.03. Counting the output layer as a parameter moved it by 0.12, from Kaplan's side of the argument to Chinchilla's, with an equally good fit. At these sizes "how many parameters" is not a settled quantity: for the smallest models the 4096-way output layer is larger than all the blocks together.
- **The optimum moves fast.** Tokens per parameter at the IsoFLOP vertex fall from 97 to 20 over two decades of compute. The smallest models want far more data per parameter than the "20 tokens per parameter" rule of thumb. That rule only appears at the top of the range.
- **The data were very quiet.** At each contour's optimum the three seeds differ by at most 0.017 bits/byte, and by 0.001–0.005 from 3×10^{14} up. The uncertainty in the exponent comes from the fitting choices (what N counts, how the valley is fitted), not from seeds.

Open threads

- **LR at the vertex.** Each size's LR was tuned once, at 2×10^7 tokens, but runs here train on 2.7×10^6 to 2.8×10^8. Halving and doubling the LR at each contour's best size would show whether the vertices move.
- **Batch size and step count.** Every run uses 16,384 tokens per step, so the shortest take 165 steps, 8 of them warmup. Large models at small budgets are short of steps rather than of tokens, which could steepen the left side of each valley and so raise a. A batch that grows with the budget would test it.
- **Contours of equal true compute.** Define the budgets by the true FLOP count instead of 6ND, as a direct check of the re-derived optimum.
- **Tied embeddings** make the output layer and the embedding one matrix and change what N counts again. **Larger budgets** run into the corpus once more: extrapolating $D^* \propto C^{0.31}$, the optimum at 10^{17} wants about 370M tokens, more than these 353M.